Policy & Strategy Lab

Case Bank: materials for the activities

Sixteen common cases used in the daily activities. Every case is stylised: places, figures, documents and people are invented for teaching, and figures are marked illustrative. Real laws, schemes and institutions are named only where the name is accurate; check current details before teaching. Cards marked *participant card* can be printed and handed out. Notes marked *facilitator only* should not be shared before the debrief.

Case	Title	Used on
1	Welfare access in a district	Day 1
2	Four vague statements	Day 2
3	Low uptake of a bicycle scheme	Day 3
4	Foundational learning: eight cause cards	Day 4
5	Primary healthcare in a hill district	Days 16 and 17
6	Banning street vending on main roads	Day 5
7	Evening buses for women workers	Day 18
8	A congestion charge: role cards	Day 7
9	School meals: an illustrative dataset	Day 12
10	Maternity benefit take-up: an evidence dossier	Days 15 and 19
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12	Women's paid work: six explanations	Day 9
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15	Teacher absence: a transfer judgement	Day 13
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Case 1. Welfare access in a district (Day 1)

Participant card. A district runs more than twenty central and state welfare schemes. At a district grievance meeting, families from remote blocks say they receive nothing, although many appear eligible. The District Collector turns to your team: what is the problem, and what do we need to find out first? You have ten minutes.

Facilitator only. Typical first drafts and what is wrong with them:

First draft	What it contains
Lack of awareness among beneficiaries	A candidate cause, placing the burden on citizens
Corruption in the delivery system	A candidate cause, stated as fact
Need for a single-window camp in each block	A solution
Poor implementation of welfare schemes	Too vague to analyse; no group, place or gap

A strong rewrite: eligible households in the district's remote blocks report not receiving benefits from the main schemes they qualify for; the District Collector must decide where in the delivery process to intervene first. Things to find out: which schemes, which households, at which stage the process fails (identification, application, approval, payment), and how the evidence compares across blocks.

Case 2. Four vague statements (Day 2)

Participant cards. One statement per card.

1. Women do not work enough in India.
2. Our cities have a waste crisis.
3. Government schools are failing.
4. Farmers do not get fair prices.

Facilitator only: model rewrites. Each names a group, place, institution, gap and decision. Brackets mark choices participants should fill with a real place and source.

Vague	A usable rewrite
Women do not work enough in India	Women aged 25 to 45 in [a named district] are far less likely than men to be in paid work [source and year]; the District Collector must decide which employment or childcare measure to prioritise next year
Our cities have a waste crisis	Most households in [a named city] hand over unseparated waste, contrary to the 2016 rules; the Municipal Commissioner must decide which compliance strategy to fund
Government schools are failing	Many children in government primary schools in [a named district] cannot read a simple text by the end of Grade 3 [source and year]; the District Education Officer must decide what to change in teacher support
Farmers do not get fair prices	Smallholders in [a named block] sell [a named crop] well below the price at the nearest regulated market [source and year]; the state agriculture marketing board must decide how to improve access

Case 3. Low uptake of a bicycle scheme (Day 3)

Participant card. Suppose a state scheme that gives bicycles to girls entering secondary school is reported to have low uptake in some districts. The state department asks why. Build the issue tree before you know anything else.

Facilitator only: a model first level (supply and demand).

Level 1	Level 2 questions
The bicycle is not offered or delivered	Are eligible girls identified? Are funds released on time? Do bicycles reach the school?
It is offered but not taken up	Do girls and families know of it? Do they want it (distance, roads, safety, norms)? Is the application process a barrier?
It is taken up but not used	Are the bicycles usable (size, quality, repair)? Do families let girls ride?

The third branch is often missed and tests collective exhaustiveness: uptake may be recorded while use is low. A driver tree version: girls attending = eligible girls times the share identified, times the share who apply, times the share who receive, times the share who use.

Case 4. Foundational learning: eight cause cards (Day 4)

Participant card (stylised district). Many children in government primary schools cannot read a simple paragraph by the end of Grade 3. Sort the eight cards and build a problem tree.

1. Teacher vacancies
2. Multigrade classrooms
3. Home language differs from the textbook language
4. Irregular attendance at harvest time
5. Assessment focused on finishing the syllabus
6. Low parental literacy
7. Frequent non-teaching duties for teachers
8. Children taught at grade level rather than at their learning level

Facilitator only: one defensible sort.

Level	Cards	Note
Proximate causes	8, 4, 3	Directly reduce effective instruction at the child's level
Structural causes	1, 7, 5, 2	Shape what teachers can do and are rewarded for
Context the system must respond to	6	A real factor, but not the end of the explanation

Debrief point: card 8 is sometimes presented as a solution (teaching at the right level). It is legitimately a cause when stated as the current practice. Card 6 is the usual trap: ending the explanation with families moves responsibility outside the school.

Case 5. Primary healthcare in a hill district (Days 16 and 17)

Participant card: the patient's journey (stylised, built as if from published field studies).

Stage	What happens
First symptom	A woman in a remote village develops a fever and cough. She waits, because a day without work means a day without wages.
Decision to seek care	After several days she decides to go. The nearest primary health centre is in the block town.
Travel	A shared jeep runs twice a day. The return trip costs more than a day's wage (illustrative).
Arrival	The medical officer's post is vacant; a nurse sees patients on some days. Medicines are often out of stock.
Referral	She is referred to the district hospital, a further day's travel away.
Outcome	She returns home without treatment and is seriously ill two weeks later.

Day 17 committee role cards. Each member questions options only on their own criterion.

Role	Criterion	Typical question
Finance officer	Cost and value	What does it cost each year, and what do we get per rupee?
Implementing official	Capacity	Who will run it, with which staff, and what happens when posts are vacant?
Citizens' representative	Distribution	Which villages and which women gain, and who is left out?
Political adviser	Support	Who will back this, who will oppose it, and can it survive a change of officer?

Budget card (illustrative). The district can commit Rs 5 crore a year: enough to fund one option fully or two partially.

Facilitator only. Four mechanisms are worth drawing out: bringing care closer (outreach clinics, telemedicine linked to a nurse), bringing people to care (subsidised transport), changing who provides care (strengthened community health workers with diagnostic kits), and changing when people seek care (wage-loss compensation). Options that are all versions of a mobile clinic are one option.

Case 6. Banning street vending on main roads (Day 5)

Participant card. A city government proposes to ban street vending on main roads to reduce congestion. Play out what might happen over twelve months.

Actor cards. Vendors; customers (many of them low-income workers); traffic police; shopkeepers on main roads; commuters.

Facilitator only: a common unintended loop.

From	To	Polarity	Mechanism
Ban enforced	Vendors move to side streets	+	Customers follow; livelihoods depend on footfall
Vendors in side streets	Side-street congestion	+	Narrower roads, same activity
Side-street congestion	Pressure to extend the ban	+	Officials respond to new complaints
Wider ban	Informal payments to continue vending	+	Enforcement creates rents

Context participants may raise: the Street Vendors (Protection of Livelihood and Regulation of Street Vending) Act, 2014 provides for town vending committees and vending zones, which changes the design options. A design fix that weakens the loop: designated vending zones near transit stops, agreed through the town vending committee.

Case 7. Evening buses for women workers (Day 18)

Participant card: the plan (stylised city). The city transport undertaking will add evening bus services on six routes linking industrial areas with residential neighbourhoods, with women conductors, better-lit stops and a helpline, funded by the state for two years.

Theory of change (as written by the planners). Funding and buses lead to extra evening services; services lead to more women travelling safely after work; that leads to more women taking or keeping evening-shift jobs.

Shock cards. Draw one every five minutes.

1. **Budget cut.** The state halves the second year's funding.
2. **Union objection.** The transport workers' union objects to new evening shifts without extra pay.
3. **Data failure.** The ticketing system fails; no ridership data for two months.
4. **Election duty.** Half the conductors and depot staff are reassigned to election duty for six weeks.
5. **Safety incident.** A widely reported incident at a bus stop causes public distrust.
6. **Guideline change.** The state changes the scheme guidelines to require a local body contribution.

Facilitator only. Fragile links usually exposed: the link from services to women travelling (it depends on perceived safety, which shock 5 hits) and the inputs to activities link (shocks 1, 2 and 4). Strong adaptations address mechanisms: a staff contingency plan for election periods, an agreed overtime arrangement, a manual ridership sample as a data fallback, and a rapid safety response that is visible to users.

Case 8. A congestion charge: role cards (Day 7)

Scenario. A large city proposes a peak-hour charge for private cars entering its central business district, with the revenue going to buses. The commissioner will announce a decision at the end of round two.

Role	Interests	Power	Red line
Municipal commissioner	Reduce congestion and pollution; avoid a political backlash	Decides, subject to the state government's support	Will not adopt a scheme the state government opposes
Traffic police	Enforceable rules; manageable workload	Controls enforcement in practice	Will not enforce without cameras and staff
Bus operators' association	More passengers; revenue for new buses	Can strike or slow services	Revenue must be ring-fenced for buses
Car owners' group	Low cost of driving; access to the centre	Vocal, well connected to councillors	No charge above a token amount
Street vendors' association	Customers on foot; no eviction	Organised but weak with officials	No clearance of vending zones
Environmental group	Cleaner air; fewer cars	Media attention; can litigate	No exemptions that hollow out the charge
Bus commuters	Faster, more frequent buses; affordable fares	None: no organisation and no seat	(No seat at the table unless another role brings them in)

Facilitator only. Watch whether anyone represents bus commuters, the largest group of beneficiaries. Use the debrief to ask why the most numerous gainers had the least influence, and what that implies for the stakeholder maps participants draw for their own cases.

Case 9. School meals: an illustrative dataset (Day 12)

Participant card. An illustrative district dataset for a school meal scheme, two years, six blocks. All figures are invented for teaching.

Block	Enrolment Y1	Enrolment Y2	Meal days Y1 (% of school days)	Meal days Y2	Complaints per 1,000 children Y1	Complaints Y2	Months reported Y1 (of 10)	Months reported Y2
A	12,000	12,200	88%	95%	4	3	10	10
B	9,000	9,100	85%	96%	5	4	10	10
C	15,000	15,500	70%	92%	6	5	10	6
D	8,000	7,800	65%	64%	7	7	10	10
E	6,000	6,100	72%	74%	3	12	10	10
F	10,000	10,300	78%	90%	5	4	10	7
District	60,000	61,000	77%	87%				

Note on the data (part of the participant card). From Year 2, the district counts a day as a meal day if meals were prepared, rather than served.

Facilitator only: the traps.

1. **Misleading average.** The district figure rises from about 77 to about 87 per cent, but most of the rise comes from blocks C and F, which have missing months.
2. **Missing months.** Blocks C and F did not report four and three months of Year 2. If the missing months were the monsoon months, when meals most often fail, their figures are inflated.
3. **Counting change.** Year 2 counts meals prepared, not served, which inflates every Year 2 figure.
4. **Helpline effect.** Block E's complaints rose sharply because a complaints helpline opened there in Year 2 (tell participants only if they ask what changed in Block E). More complaints may mean better access to complain.
5. **The block that did not move.** Block D, the most remote, shows no improvement on any measure.

An honest summary: reported meal days rose, but a change in counting and missing months mean we cannot say service improved; Block D shows no improvement at all; Block E's complaints probably reflect the new helpline rather than worse service.

Case 10. Maternity benefit take-up: an evidence dossier (Days 15 and 19)

Participant card (stylised district; all findings illustrative). Take-up of a maternity benefit scheme is low. Six findings:

#	Finding	Source type
F1	In three blocks, registered pregnancies far exceed approved claims	Administrative data from the district portal
F2	Many applications were rejected because the name on the bank account did not match the identity document	An audit of a sample of rejected applications
F3	Women working as agricultural labourers said they did not apply because they could not leave work to visit the centre	A published field study in two blocks
F4	Anganwadi workers reported that the online portal was frequently unavailable during the application period	Minutes of a district review meeting
F5	A worker was reported to have asked for money to process forms	One newspaper report
F6	Women are unaware of the scheme	An assertion in a district note, with no source

Facilitator only. Tags: F1 fact (administrative); F2 fact (audit sample); F3 fact for the two blocks, inference beyond them; F4 fact as reported, weak on frequency; F5 a single anecdote; F6 an assumption. A well-supported governing message: take-up is low mainly because the application process screens out eligible women, through document mismatches, the cost of visiting the centre and portal failures, rather than because women are unaware. Three key lines: documents (F2), access costs (F3), system failures (F4), with F1 establishing the gap. F5 and F6 should not carry the argument.

For Day 19, the decision for the District Collector might be: authorise assisted applications at anganwadi centres with on-the-spot correction of document mismatches, and set an outage protocol for the portal.

Case 11. Dengue: ten leaves to prune (Day 8)

Participant card. A municipal health department wants to reduce dengue cases this monsoon. The issue tree has ten leaves.

1. Water collecting in construction sites
2. Household water storage
3. Blocked drains
4. Late case reporting by private clinics
5. Fogging coverage
6. Public awareness
7. Housing for migrant construction workers
8. Vacancies among vector surveillance staff
9. Laboratory testing capacity
10. Coordination between the health and engineering departments

Facilitator only. There is no single right answer. Good pruning keeps leaves with large effects within the department's reach (often 1, 4, 8 and 10) and writes reasons for each cut. Challenge pods that keep 6 because it is easy to research, and pods that cut 7 because it is uncomfortable.

Case 12. Women's paid work: six explanations (Day 9)

Participant cards (a stylised district with growing towns). One explanation per pod: care responsibilities; a lack of suitable local jobs; social norms about women's work; safety and transport; a mismatch of skills and education; household income (as household incomes rise, some women withdraw from paid work).

Prompt on each card. Turn the explanation into a testable hypothesis. What comparison would show it to be wrong?

Facilitator only. The Periodic Labour Force Survey is the obvious public source for participation rates; at district level its estimates may be imprecise. Strong disconfirming tests use comparisons: women with and without young children; towns with and without new local employers; areas with and without safe evening transport. Several explanations can be true at once.

Case 13. Late wage payments: designing around missing data (Day 10)

Participant card. A state wants to know why wage payments under the rural employment guarantee reach some workers late in a stylised district. You have four weeks, no field access and only published sources. Assume you cannot obtain worker-level payment records with reasons for delay in that time.

Source menu card. The scheme's public management information system reports; social audit reports; CAG audit reports; parliamentary standing committee reports; published research studies; credible reporting.

Facilitator only. The scheme's public reporting is often richer than participants expect, including information on payment processing stages. Good plans compare stages of the payment process across blocks and over time, and state as a limitation that published data may not distinguish between causes of delay at the worker level.

Case 14. The evidence hunt: four questions (Day 11)

Participant cards. One question per pod; twenty minutes.

1. How has the share of children in a chosen state who can read a Grade 2 text changed over the last decade?
2. Are sanctioned posts in primary health centres in a chosen state filled?
3. What has the CAG said about solid waste management in a chosen state?
4. How much did a chosen state budget for school meals last year, and how much did it spend?

Facilitator only: where good answers start.

Question	Primary sources to look for
1	Pratham's Annual Status of Education Report (state tables); the National Achievement Survey for comparison
2	The Ministry of Health and Family Welfare's annual health infrastructure and human resources statistics
3	CAG performance and compliance audit reports for the state, searched by sector
4	The state budget documents (demands for grants), PRS state budget analyses, and scheme reports for releases and spending

Case 15. Teacher absence: a transfer judgement (Day 13)

Participant cards: two stylised states.

Feature	State A (the apparent success)	State B (the adopter)
Components	Biometric attendance; community monitoring through school committees; fewer non-teaching duties	Plans to copy all three
Supervision	Block officers review attendance data weekly and act on it	Block officer posts often vacant
Community bodies	Active school committees with trained members	Committees exist on paper
Non-teaching duties	Reduced by a state order, enforced by the district	Teachers routinely assigned to surveys and elections
Connectivity	Reliable in most schools	Patchy in remote areas

Facilitator only. The biometric system is the form that travels most easily and works least without the supervision behind it. Strong transfer judgements: build supervision and reduce non-teaching duties first; pilot the attendance system where connectivity and block staffing exist; treat community monitoring as a longer-term investment.

Case 16. Follow the money: four services (Day 6)

Participant cards. One service per pod: wage payments under the rural employment guarantee; school meals (PM POSHAN); staffing at primary health centres; a city bus service.

Facilitator only: what good answers should find. Verify each point against the current guidelines and the Constitution before teaching; funding patterns change.

Service	Legislative authority	Administration	Money (verify current pattern)
Rural employment guarantee	Union law (2005)	States, districts and gram panchayats	The Union pays the bulk, including unskilled wages; states share material and some other costs
School meals (PM POSHAN)	Education is on the Concurrent List	State education departments and schools	Centrally sponsored, with a Union and state sharing pattern set in the guidelines
Primary health centre staffing	Public health is on the State List	State health departments	State budgets, with support from the National Health Mission
City bus service	State subject; often run by state transport undertakings or city bodies	State or municipal transport bodies	State and city budgets, fares, and in some cases central schemes